sharp at six. Taking reports has always been a mandatory routine task before and after any kind of fall-in or parade, to account for missing persons or persons employed elsewhere. There's a disciplined procedure of its own that all of us would be taught in due time. After the report was over, the PT ustads of the respective squadrons took their squads for a three-kilometre run, followed by a back-breaking session of physical training. Exhausted from forty-five minutes of PT parade, we wolfed down our breakfast, went to our cabins for a quick shower and gathered outside the FCM again for another central fall-in. The entire day's schedule was then announced to us. Bicycles were issued in the administrative block. 'Take care of your bicycles better than your boyfriends' is what was commonly said, and, quite truly, these bicycles would be our only mode of conveyance and any malfunction of it would mean being late and, ultimately, more punishments. Each bicycle was allotted a number for identification. The next thing on the schedule was the issue of various uniforms and overalls that we would require during training. We were dispersed for lunch after an address by the chief instructor, in which we were told the detailed schedule for the next six months.

There was a different schedule for cadets who had qualified for flying and those who had qualified for technical or administrative duties. Flying cadets would undergo a mechanical conversion flight course on an HPT-32 fixed wing aircraft for four weeks, before they were allowed to even go near an actual aircraft. They would be taught the basics of flying, including engine, airframe and everything technical related to the flying of an aircraft. They would be made to appear for an exam after that, and only those who would pass would be taught to fly. All this while, the daily schedule would remain unchanged. The day would start with a rigorous PT or drill parade, followed by classes until we broke for lunch. Preparation of upcoming sports events would continue during the games parade. Open-door study period would be observed religiously, followed by dinner and the usual ragda session until midnight or, at times, even till first light.

Four weeks passed without me realizing that the exam had edged closer; I had wasted most of my free time compensating for my lack of sleep. But